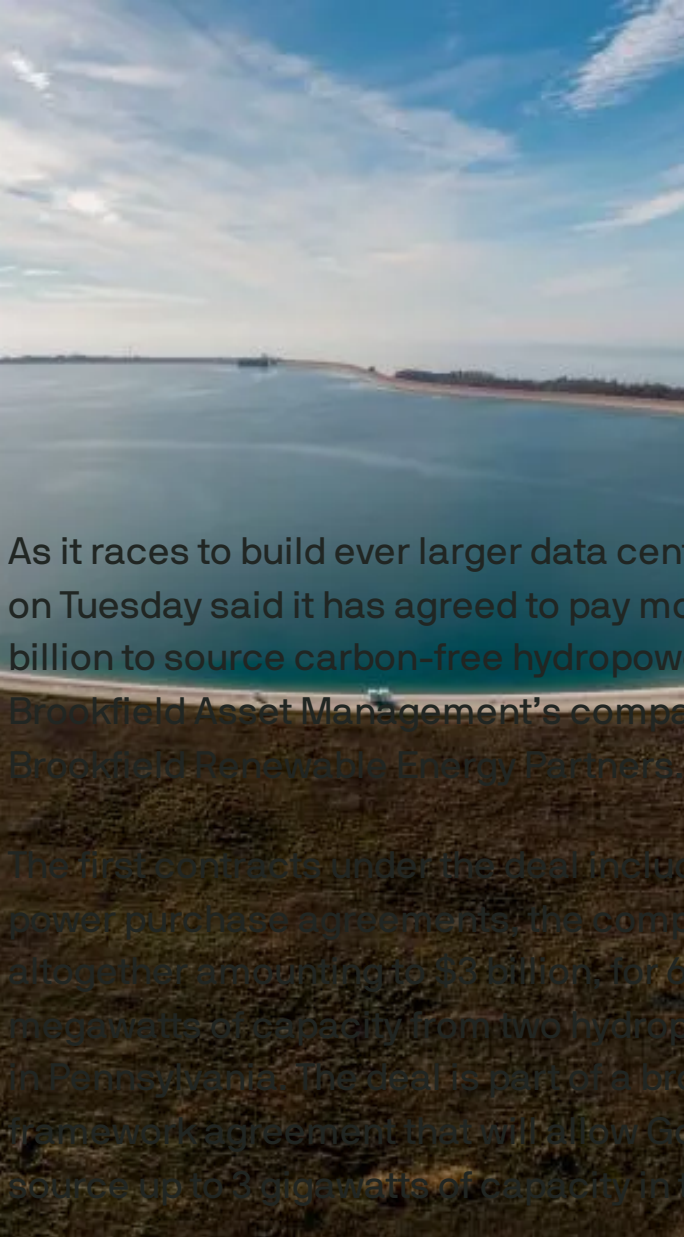


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Google inks \$3B deal to buy hydropower from Brookfield



As it races to build ever larger data centers, Google on Tuesday said it has agreed to pay more than \$3 billion to source carbon-free hydropower from Brookfield Asset Management's company, Brookfield Renewable Energy Partners.

The first contracts under the deal include 20-year power purchase agreements, the companies said, altogether amounting to \$3 billion, for 670 megawatts of capacity from two hydropower plants in Pennsylvania. The deal is part of a broader framework agreement that will allow Google to source up to 3 gigawatts of capacity in total.

IMAGE CREDITS:

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The deal comes as Google and its hyperscaler rivals, Meta, Amazon, and Microsoft, seek to source power for their seemingly ever-expanding data centers that they use to house, train, and host the AI tools that underpin the tech sector's current boom.

This renewed demand for power has [breathed new life](#) into nuclear energy, boosted [gas generation](#), and brought back focus on [renewable energy](#). Google itself has [committed tens of billions](#) to making sure it won't run out of power; Meta more or less [bought](#) a nuclear plant; and Microsoft has struck a deal to source power for 20 years from [a](#)

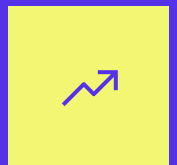
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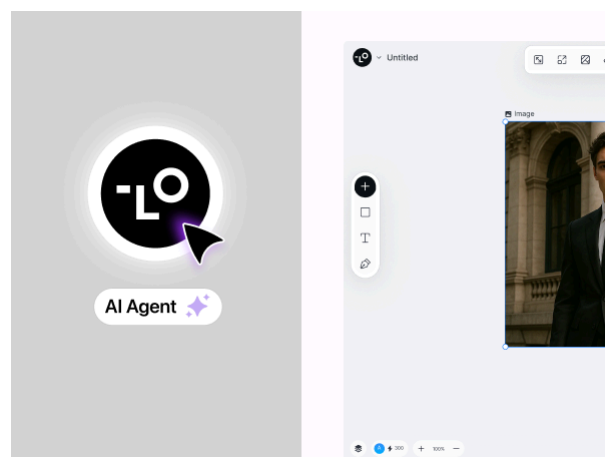
Power aside, renewable energy also presents an attractive opportunity for these companies to continue working towards their net-zero targets even as their burgeoning data centers add to their carbon emissions.

Brookfield Renewable Partners, which operates renewable energy plants in the U.S., said its two hydropower facilities in Pennsylvania, Holtwood and Safe Harbor, will be relicensed, upgraded, or overhauled to meet the new requirements.

“This collaboration with Brookfield is a significant step forward, ensuring clean energy supply in the PJM region where we operate. Hydropower is a proven, low-cost technology, offering dependable, homegrown, carbon-free electricity that creates jobs and builds a stronger grid for all,” Amanda Peterson Corio, head of data center energy at Google, said in a statement.

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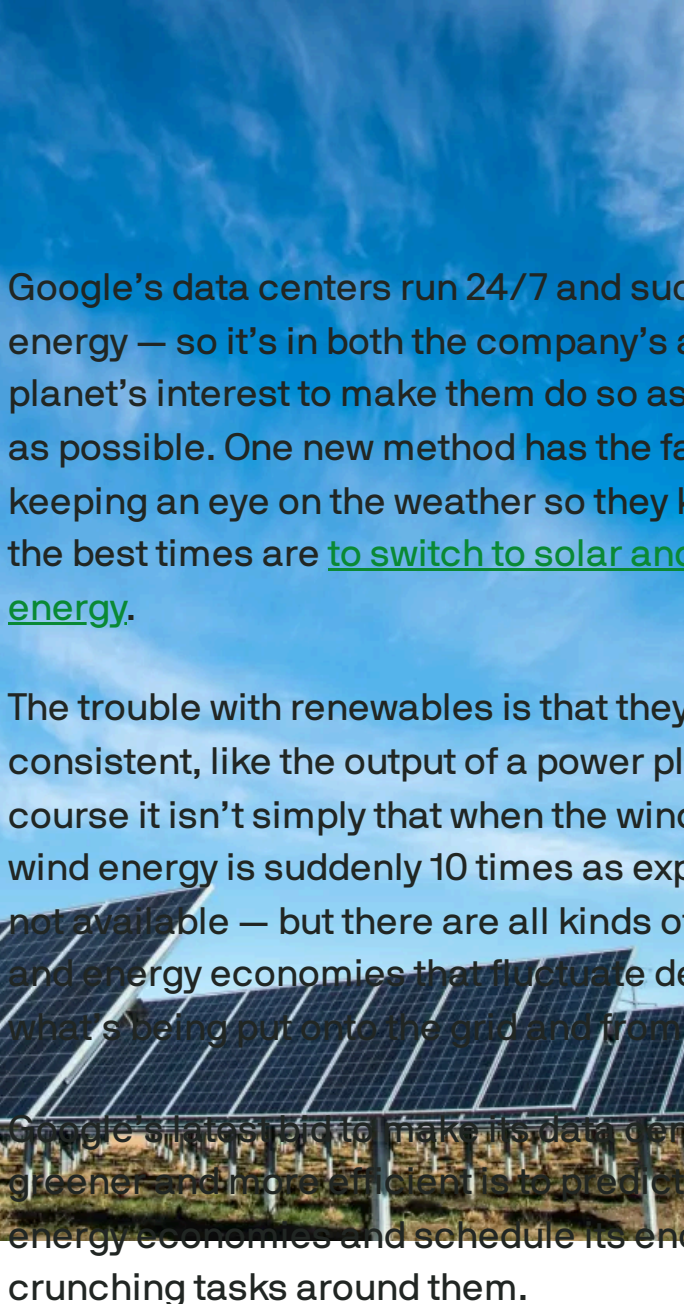
Ram is a financial and tech reporter and editor. He covered North American and European M&A, equity, regulatory...

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Google data centers watch the weather to make the most of renewable energy



Google’s data centers run 24/7 and suck up a ton of energy — so it’s in both the company’s and the planet’s interest to make them do so as efficiently as possible. One new method has the facilities keeping an eye on the weather so they know when the best times are [to switch to solar and wind energy](#).

The trouble with renewables is that they’re not consistent, like the output of a power plant. Of course it isn’t simply that when the wind dies down, wind energy is suddenly 10 times as expensive or not available — but there are all kinds of exchanges and energy economies that fluctuate depending on what’s being put onto the grid and from where.

Google’s stated goal to make its data centers greener and more efficient is to predict those energy economies and schedule its endless data-crunching tasks around them.

It’s not that someone at Google looks up the actual weather for the next day and calculates how much solar energy will be contributed in a given region and when. Turns out there are people who can do that for you! In this case a Danish greentech firm called [Tomorrow](#).

“Organizations are realizing that using electricity at the right time and the right place allows them to reduce both their costs and their carbon footprint,” said Tomorrow CEO in a press release.

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THIS HELPFUL VISUALIZATION SHOWS HOW IT MIGHT WORK - SHIFT
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What Google is doing is watching this schedule of carbon-heavy and renewable-heavy periods on the grid and shuffling things around on its end to take advantage of them. By stacking all its heavy compute tasks into time slots where the extra power they will draw is taken from mostly renewable energy sources, they can reduce their reliance on carbon-heavy power.



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It only works if you have the kind of fluid and predictable digital work that Google has nurtured. When energy is expensive or dirty, the bare minimum of sending emails and serving YouTube videos is more than enough to keep its data centers busy. But when it's cheap and green, compute-heavy tasks like training machine learning models or video transcoding can run wild.

This informed time-shifting is a smart and intuitive idea, though from Google's post it's not clear how effective it really is. Usually when the company announces some effort like this, it's accompanied by estimates of how much energy is saved or efficiency gained. In the case of this time-shifting experiment, the company is uncharacteristically conservative:

“Results from our pilot suggest that by shifting compute jobs we can increase the amount of lower-carbon energy we consume.”

That's a lot of hedging for something that sounds like a home run on paper. A full research paper is forthcoming, but I asked Google for more information. Shortly after posting this I received the following response from Ana Radovanovic, technical lead for the project:

Early results for the new system are promising, however, as you note, we are not sharing specific metrics at this time. Our team plans to publish a scientific paper later in the year which will contain a detailed overview of the load shifting methodology and the observed results from our roll out.

How much a single data center facility or an entire fleet can increase its use of renewable energy is dependent on a number of variables. As such, we are taking time to conduct additional analysis before we share specific numbers.

It seems they are holding off in order to better estimate the effect, but today being Earth Day it makes sense to publish the news early and augment it with more data later.

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Google launches clean energy project in Taiwan, its first in Asia

Google has [launched its first clean energy project in Asia](#). The company announced today that it struck a long-term agreement to buy the output of a 10-megawatt solar array in Tainan City, Taiwan, about 100 km south of its data center in the country. Google already has solar and wind projects across North and South America, as well as Europe.

The agreement is a collaboration between Google, several Taiwanese energy companies and the country's government, which recently revised Taiwan's Electricity Act to enable non-utility companies to purchase renewable energy directly. The revisions are part of [Taiwan's new energy policy](#), aimed at phasing out nuclear energy by 2025 and increasing the share of electricity generated from renewable sources to 20 percent.

Google is the first corporate power buyer to take advantage of the revised law. Its development partners are Diode Ventures, Taiyen Green Energy, J&V Energy and New Green Power.

The solar array will be connected to the same regional power grid at Google's Chuanghua County data center, one of two in Asia (the other is in Singapore). The poles supporting the solar panels will be mounted into commercial fishing ponds, an arrangement that Marsden Hanna, Google's senior lead of energy and infrastructure, said in a blog post will maximize land-use efficiency and respect the local ecology because "fish and solar panels

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can coexist peacefully.” Fishing pond owners will also be compensated for hosting the panels.

The agreement means Google will get a long-term, fixed electricity price for its operations in Taiwan.

“As the Taiwanese government pursues further measures to remove market barriers and reduce renewable energy costs, we’re hopeful that more companies will purchase renewable energy, driving even larger projects across Taiwan,” said Hanna.

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Catherine Shu covered startups in Asia and breaking news for TechCrunch. Her reporting has also appeared in the...

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